

World in Brief: Meta's blockbuster settlement; catastrophic floods sweep Nepal



Photograph: Getty Images

Meta agreed to pay as much as \$16.7bn to settle a blockbuster lawsuit brought by a group of 29 American states. The lawsuit **claimed** that the social media giant designed Facebook and Instagram to keep children addicted and misled the public about the risks. The proposed settlement mandates new restrictions on Meta's platforms, including limits to the amount of time young people can spend scrolling.

At least 95 people died and hundreds more were missing after **floods** devastated communities along **Nepal's** border with Tibet. Hundreds of foreign visitors are among those unaccounted for. Rescue teams from Nepal and China are searching the area. Officials are investigating whether a magnitude-4.4 earthquake dislodged ice and rock, setting off the disaster.

Brent crude fell to \$86 a barrel on reports that **Iran** and **Oman** were again discussing "a joint temporary navigational corridor" through the **Strait of Hormuz**. The move is more evidence that Iran's trading partners have not been cowed by America's **threat** of economic warfare. China, which buys around 90% of Iranian oil,

said that America's sanctions were illegal and that its trade with the Islamic Republic "should not be interfered with or disrupted".

The **Trump administration** suspended applications for **immigrant visas** globally while consular officers are trained to screen out individuals who might need public assistance. The government claimed that the measure, part of a [wider crackdown](#) on immigration, would ensure a "more prosperous America". A federal judge last week struck down Donald Trump's ban on applicants from 75 poorer countries.

The commander of the **Syrian Democratic Forces** said the Kurdish-led militia was disbanding and merging with the Syrian Army. The force was once America's main partner in fighting ISIS in Syria and controlled the country's north-east for more than a decade. But President Ahmed al-Sharaa's troops took much of that territory earlier this year. The SDF's commander said it would help build "the new [Syria](#)".

At least 14 newborn babies died in a fire at a hospital in Islamabad, **Pakistan's** capital. The blaze began after an air-conditioning unit exploded; nearby oxygen cylinders caused the fire to spread rapidly through a maternity ward, according to Pakistan's health minister. One of the babies in the ward was rescued. Shehbaz Sharif, the prime minister, has ordered an investigation.

American officials accused **China** of conducting a vast **cyber attack**. Hackers allegedly targeted government agencies, including NASA, the Federal Reserve and the Department of Justice, using Nanjing Xinjiuwei, a Chinese technology firm. Hospitals, power companies, defence contractors and military networks were also targeted. Officials did not disclose the extent of the damage.

Figure of the day: 2.5m tonnes, the expected combined weight of wheat exports from Ukraine and Russia in August—well below last year's 6.3m tonnes. [Read about](#) the threat to global grain supplies.

*Curious about the world and the forces that are changing it?
Expand your mind with [Simply Science](#), our science newsletter.*

US in Brief: Darline Graham's victory



Photograph: Reuters

Darline Graham won **South Carolina's** Republican Senate primary in what was widely seen as a test of Donald Trump's endorsement power. Ms Graham, a newcomer who admitted last week that she is "not that informed on national security", beat Ralph Norman, a congressman, in the snap Senate primary to replace [Lindsey Graham](#), Ms Graham's brother who died in July. Mr Trump held a rare in-person rally for Ms Graham and spent significantly on her campaign— [more support](#) than he has offered many battleground Republicans—even though the runoff will not help to determine control of Congress.

There was more good news for Mr Trump in **Oklahoma**. Mike Mazzei, a former state senator backed by the president, notched a narrow win over Gentner Drummond, the attorney-general, in the Republican primary runoff for governor. It is a turnaround: the president's initial choices were defeated in several gubernatorial primaries earlier this year. None of his preferred candidates for the Senate have lost so far.

The Pentagon's Southern Command struck an **alleged drug-smuggling boat** in the Caribbean, killing four people. It said "confirmed intelligence" had "revealed the vessel's active involvement in narco-trafficking". That marks the second [such attack](#) this week after a two-month lull: on Sunday another strike

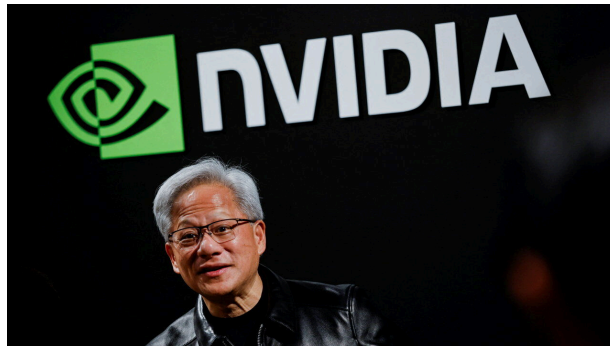
killed two on a boat in the eastern Pacific. Democratic lawmakers continue to question the intelligence behind the attacks.

The State Department said it will revoke the **visas** of foreigners who entered America on [short-term permits](#) and subsequently claimed asylum. A report by the Department of Homeland Security in 2022 found that more than a third of those who claimed asylum in the previous decade had first arrived on B1 and B2 visas designed for business visitors and tourists. The State Department said revocations would occur on a “rolling basis”.

SpaceX, Elon Musk’s [rocketry firm](#), said that it will spend at least \$100bn building a new launch site in Louisiana. The “self-sustaining spaceport” will, the firm hopes, support “thousands” of Starship rocket flights annually. Construction begins next year. Starship is currently launched from the company’s Starbase facility in Texas. SpaceX is also adding two launch pads in Florida. Shares rose after the announcement.

Two people died from **measles** in Pennsylvania, the country’s first deaths from the disease this year. America is grappling with its largest measles outbreak in three decades: the Centres for Disease Control and Prevention has confirmed 2,777 cases so far in 2026 and warns of [falling vaccination rates among children](#). [In 2025](#) three people died from measles in America, the first reported deaths since 2015.

Nvidia's risky plan to sustain the AI boom



Photograph: Reuters

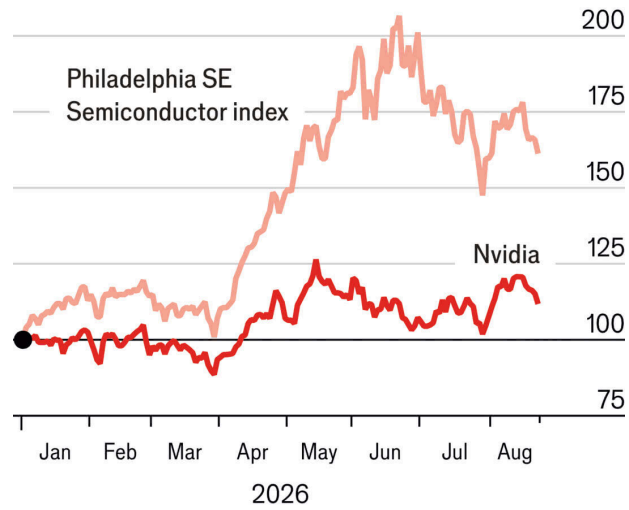
On Wednesday Nvidia, the world's most valuable company, reports quarterly results for the three months to July 26th. Analysts expect revenue to exceed \$92bn, almost twice as much as in the same period last year. Yet its share price has risen by just 12% since the start of 2026, only about a fifth as much as an index of leading chipmakers.

Jensen Huang, the company's boss, has responded with a [burst of dealmaking](#) designed to boost demand for its chips. On August 10th he announced a partnership with six big Wall Street firms, including BlackRock and Goldman Sachs, that aims to raise \$500bn to finance AI infrastructure. A week later, Nvidia agreed to provide up to \$105bn of credit support to help OpenAI, an AI lab, lease a vast data centre in Ohio.

Such deals have raised concerns about “circular financing”: Nvidia helping fund the customers that buy its chips. Mr Huang must persuade investors that the extra demand this creates justifies the financial risk Nvidia is taking.

Chip happens

Share prices, January 1st 2026=100



Source: LSEG Workspace

Investors learn to live with inflation



Photograph: FRANCK ROBICHON/EPA/Shutterstock

For much of the early 2020s, investors debated whether central banks could tame inflation without causing a recession (a “soft landing”) or whether higher interest rates would ground economic growth with a painful jolt. **Neither happened.** Inflation remains above central-bank targets in much of the rich world, even as economies keep growing.

Data on Wednesday will show whether price pressures are still building. America releases the PCE price index (the Fed’s preferred inflation gauge); Australia reports inflation figures; and Japan producer-price data. Higher energy prices since the war with Iran have added to inflationary pressure. In a recent survey 54% of fund managers expected the global economy to remain in such a state over the coming year.

Markets have adapted. Share prices have risen, thanks in part to surprisingly fast earnings growth. Bonds, which mostly promise fixed payments, have suffered. But learning to live with higher inflation does not make it benign: it can make investors and consumers behave erratically, making markets—and the economy—more volatile.

Donald Trump targets Lisa Cook (again)



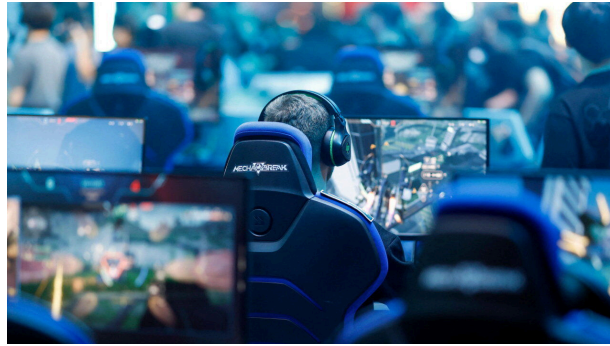
Photograph: Getty Images

Lisa Cook, a governor of the Federal Reserve, has until Wednesday to respond to a letter from the White House containing allegations of mortgage fraud, sent as part of Donald Trump's latest attempt to dismiss her from her post. The Supreme Court ruled in June that presidents may fire Fed governors only for cause. But before taking action, the president must provide prior notice and hold a hearing—steps Mr Trump initially skipped.

Ms Cook is accused of making false statements on mortgage applications by listing homes in both Michigan and Georgia as her primary residence. She denies any wrongdoing; her lawyers have dismissed the charges, labelling them as “baseless”. A federal district court will judge whether these claims satisfy the legal threshold for removal.

If Mr Trump successfully [removes Ms Cook](#) and appoints an ally, he would have a Republican-appointed majority on the board, strengthening his hand as he pushes for lower interest rates. A victory could also make it easier for presidents to remove Fed governors in future, weakening the central bank's independence.

Game over for consoles?



Photograph: Alamy

Gamers will brave lengthy queues in Cologne to be among the first to play upcoming releases when Gamescom, the world's largest video-game trade fair, begins on Wednesday. Yet the industry itself is struggling. A boom in demand for memory chips from AI firms has pushed up hardware costs, making consoles more expensive and frustrating gamers accustomed to tech getting cheaper over time. Gamers have dubbed the squeeze “RAMmageddon”—a nod to the soaring cost of random-access memory chips.

Software is under pressure, too. [Blockbuster games](#) are becoming ever more expensive and time-consuming to produce, leaving longer gaps between big-budget releases. Meanwhile smartphones compete for players' time and money. Studios have responded with sweeping job cuts.

The industry is pinning its hopes on “Grand Theft Auto VI”, the latest instalment in the crime series, to provide a huge boost to console sales. But Gamescom visitors will not get to play it: Rockstar Games, its American developer, routinely skips the fair.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Which 1987 comedy film features a narration by Peter Falk, the star of the Columbo TV series?

Tuesday: What type of creature did Daryl Hannah play in the film “Splash”?

*I am a self-made woman, and I
have the doctor bills to prove it.*

Dolly Parton